



The Apology

Everyone says sorry, but hardly anyone is taught how. In this hour students sort real apologies from the ones that only sound like it, learn the four parts of a proper one, then rewrite a bad apology in pairs and mark somebody else's. It is an hour about accountability: owning what you did rather than explaining it away.

Before you start. The exit slip is about something real, and one or two will be about something at home. Do not collect them. Stay in the room where a student can come and speak to you at the end, and treat anything disclosed as you would any other disclosure. Slide 12 mentions somebody who is no longer around, so check for recent bereavements first.

Print these

Page	What it is	How many
Page 2	The four parts, for reference	Project it, or one per table
Page 3	Starter cards	One set per pair, cut up
Page 4	Scenario cards	Enough for one card per pair, cut up
Page 5	The rewrite sheet	One per pair
Page 6	Exit slips	One per student, cut up

How it works

Minutes	What happens	Slides
0 to 6	Starter. Cards on the tables, and pairs sort them into real apologies and not.	3
6 to 10	Feedback. Reveal the three real ones, then the three moves the others make.	4 to 5
10 to 18	Teach the four parts, then find all four in the worked before-and-after.	6 to 7
18 to 24	Rebuild one bad apology together, and put the finished version on the board.	8
24 to 36	In pairs, one scenario card per pair. They rewrite the apology on the sheet.	9
36 to 42	Sheets move two tables along and are marked against the four parts.	10
42 to 54	Three hard questions in pairs, then why an apology is not a request for forgiveness.	11 to 12
54 to 60	Exit slip, one they actually owe. Folded, kept, never collected.	13 to 14

Worth knowing

- In forty-five minutes: cut the class rebuild on slide 8 and the discussion on slide 11, and give the pairs eight minutes instead of twelve. Keep the starter and the exit slip.

Saying what you did, and what you will do instead, is the part people remember.





The four parts

Project this, or print it and put it on the tables while they write.

1 Name what you did.

Not “what happened” and not “the situation”. What you did, in your own words, plainly. If the sentence has no I in it, it is not there yet.

2 Say why it landed the way it did.

Show that you understand the effect on them, not just the rule you broke. This is the part that tells somebody you actually thought about it.

3 Stop.

No but. No explaining what was going on for you. No asking whether things are okay now. Everything after but is what you really meant, and they can hear it.

4 Say what you will do differently.

One specific thing. “I will not do it again” is weaker than “I will not bring it up in front of other people”.

The same apology, twice

BEFORE

“Sorry if you got upset about the group chat thing, but you know what you’re like.”

AFTER

“I left you out of the group chat and then laughed when you asked about it. That was humiliating. I am not doing it again, and I will say so to the others.”

Every one of the four parts is in the version on the right, in order. Ask the class to point at each one before you move on.



Is this an apology?

Eight to a sheet. One set per pair. They sort into two piles. They will disagree, and that is the point.

1 APOLOGY OR NOT “I’m sorry you took it that way.”	2 APOLOGY OR NOT “I shouldn’t have said it in front of everyone. That was embarrassing for you.”
3 APOLOGY OR NOT “Mistakes were made.”	4 APOLOGY OR NOT “Sorry, but you started it.”
5 APOLOGY OR NOT “I was wrong, and I am not going to do it again.”	6 APOLOGY OR NOT “I apologise if anyone was offended.”
7 APOLOGY OR NOT “I know saying sorry doesn’t undo it. I’ll walk in with you tomorrow.”	8 APOLOGY OR NOT “I’m sorry, I was only joking.”

Answers: two, five and seven are the real ones. The other five all blame the person who was hurt, leave out who did it, or cancel themselves out.





The scenario cards

Six to a sheet. Print enough for one card per pair. Each comes with the apology somebody actually gave, which is the thing they are fixing.

SCENARIO 1

You repeated something a friend told you in confidence.

“Sorry, I didn’t think it was a secret.”

SCENARIO 2

You promised to cover a shift and did not turn up. Your friend got in trouble.

“Sorry about that, I’ve had so much on.”

SCENARIO 3

You made a joke about the way somebody speaks and the room laughed.

“It was banter, sorry if you took it the wrong way.”

SCENARIO 4

You lost your temper with your younger brother over nothing.

“Sorry, but you were really annoying me.”

SCENARIO 5

You took the credit in front of a teacher for work your partner did most of.

“Sorry, you should have said something at the time.”

SCENARIO 6

You read a message off somebody’s phone out loud to make people laugh.

“I’m sorry you got embarrassed.”





The rewrite sheet

One per pair. Do not put your names on it. Another pair is going to mark it.

Scenario number: _____

1. What you did.

2. Why it landed the way it did.

3. Stop. Read it back and cross out any but.

Nothing goes here. That is the point of it.

4. What you will do differently.

Marked by another pair

- ☐ Does it say what they did, in their own words?
- ☐ Does it show they understand why it mattered?
- ☐ Is there a but anywhere in it? Circle it.
- ☐ Is there one specific thing they will do differently?

Which part is weakest, and why?





One you actually owe

Six to a sheet. One per student. Not collected, not read, not marked. Say that before you hand them out.



ONE YOU ACTUALLY OWE

To (initials are fine):

Fold it. Keep it.



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